

# Admin Hours Calculator

*What is your team's admin paperwork actually costing you in dollars and lost focus? Do the math in 10 minutes.*

**From HitLai Institute — Module S3: “AI That Does Your Paperwork”**

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## WHY THIS EXERCISE MATTERS

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Most SMB owners assume “admin work is just part of doing business.” It isn't. It's a hidden second salary distributed across people who were hired for something else. This worksheet makes that cost visible.

You will likely discover that 30-50% of someone's job is paperwork — and that recovering even half of those hours funds 5-10x the cost of any reasonable AI subscription.

Fill it in once. Keep the result. Re-check after 90 days of running one flow.

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## STEP 1: LIST EVERY RECURRING ADMIN TASK

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Use this template. Don't aim for completeness on first pass — capture the obvious 8-10. You can extend later.

| Task                        | Frequency            | Hours per occurrence | Who does it | Touches which systems             |
|-----------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|-------------|-----------------------------------|
| Invoice intake & data entry | weekly               | —                    | —           | accounting, email, file storage   |
| Weekly status report        | weekly               | —                    | —           | CRM, accounting, ops tools, email |
| Contract review & filing    | per signing          | —                    | —           | DMS, CRM, calendar                |
| Customer onboarding         | per new customer     | —                    | —           | CRM, email, file storage          |
| Expense receipt processing  | weekly               | —                    | —           | bookkeeping, email                |
| Quote / proposal formatting | per quote            | —                    | —           | CRM, doc tool, email              |
| Payroll prep                | monthly/<br>biweekly | —                    | —           | payroll, HRIS                     |
| Inventory reconciliation    | weekly               | —                    | —           | inventory, accounting             |
| Tax doc collection          | quarterly            | —                    | —           | accounting, file storage          |
| Compliance/<br>audit prep   | per audit            | —                    | —           | varies                            |
|                             |                      |                      |             |                                   |

## STEP 2: CONVERT TO MONTHLY HOURS AND DOLLARS

For each task, calculate monthly hours and apply the right hourly cost:

| Task         | Monthly hrs | Hourly cost (loaded) | Monthly \$ |
|--------------|-------------|----------------------|------------|
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
|              | ___         | \$___                | \$___      |
| <b>Total</b> | ___         |                      | **\$___**  |

**Hourly cost (loaded) = (annual salary + benefits + overhead) ÷ 2,000.** For a \$60K salaried employee, that's roughly \$40-\$45/hr. For your own time, use the highest-value billable rate you have — the work you couldn't take on because you were doing paperwork is the real cost.

### STEP 3: THE OPPORTUNITY COST

Most of these tasks aren't just "expensive" — they pull your most capable people off higher-value work.

| Line                                                                                              | Your number |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>A. Total monthly admin hours</b><br>(from Step 2)                                              | _____ hrs   |
| <b>B. Of those, hours done by</b><br>people whose primary role is<br>sales, delivery, or strategy | _____ hrs   |
| <b>C. Recoverable strategic</b><br><b>capacity per month (B)</b>                                  | _____ hrs   |
| <b>D. Annualized (C × 12)</b>                                                                     | _____ hrs   |

If D is over 200 hours, you have effectively half a sales rep, project manager, or partner stuck on admin. Recovering them is a hiring decision you're making by default.

### STEP 4: WHAT AI + YOUR TEAM + YOUR SYSTEMS REALISTICALLY SAVES

Be honest. AI doesn't save 100% of any flow — your team always does the edge cases.

| Task                | Monthly hrs (current) | Realistic % saved with AI + flow | Hours saved      | \$ saved           |
|---------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------|------------------|--------------------|
| Invoice intake      | ___                   | 70-85%                           | ___              | \$___              |
| Weekly report       | ___                   | 80-90%                           | ___              | \$___              |
| Contract review     | ___                   | 30-50%                           | ___              | \$___              |
| Customer onboarding | ___                   | 60-75%                           | ___              | \$___              |
| Expense receipts    | ___                   | 75-90%                           | ___              | \$___              |
| (other)             | ___                   | ___%                             | ___              | \$___              |
| <b>Total saved</b>  |                       |                                  | <b>** ___ **</b> | <b>**\$ ___ **</b> |

## STEP 5: THE HONEST SUBSCRIPTION-COST CHECK

| Line                                                                 | Your number |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>E.</b> Total monthly \$ saved (Step 4 total)                      | \$___       |
| <b>F.</b> Monthly subscription cost of the tool you're considering   | \$___       |
| <b>G. Net monthly savings (E – F)</b>                                | \$___       |
| <b>H. Months to ROI</b> (one-time setup time × your hourly rate ÷ G) | ___         |

If G is positive within month 2, the math works. If not, you may be overestimating “% saved” — recalibrate downward and try again.

## STEP 6: PICK ONE TO START

Looking at your Step 4 list, pick the ONE task that: 1. Has the highest dollar savings, AND 2. Is “Low” risk on the Starter Kit ranking, AND 3. Touches systems you already use daily

That’s your first flow. Don’t try to fix three things at once — pilot, measure, expand.

**Your first flow:** \_\_\_\_\_

## THE TWO COSTS YOU CAN'T PUT IN A TABLE

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1. **Context-switching tax.** Every time someone interrupts strategic work to handle a 5-minute admin task, the real cost is 25 minutes — the time to refocus. The hours in your table understate the damage.
2. **Drift in standards.** When admin is rushed, things get filed wrong, miscategorized, or forgotten. The cost of finding a misfiled contract two years later, or paying a vendor twice because the first invoice never got reconciled, doesn't show up in any monthly report.

Both costs disappear when AI, your team, and your systems are running together — because the work happens consistently the first time, in the systems your team already uses.

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## THE HITLAI ANSWER, IN ONE LINE

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AI tools, your team, your systems — running together, safely.

For paperwork: AI extracts and drafts. Your accounting, CRM, calendar, and filing systems take what's approved. Your team owns the exceptions. AI starts where you're comfortable — watching, suggesting, executing-with-approval — and earns the right to do more.

Works with what you've got — Microsoft 365, QuickBooks, Xero, your CRM, the AI you already use. What we don't have a connector for, the platform builds automatically in minutes, reviewed before it goes live. Every step auditable.

**Want to fill this worksheet in live with your real numbers?** Bring two weeks of paperwork data to Module S3 and we'll do it together. → [hitlai.net/institute](https://hitlai.net/institute)

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